Jigme Wangchuk, who became king in 1926. More schools, dispensaries, and roads were built. Monasteries and local governmental bodies were brought under central, royal control. But there was still a shabdrung, and he challenged, unsuccessfully, Jigme Wangchuk's accession to the throne.

In the spring of 1931, in a vain attempt to restore his powers, the then shabdrung, Jigme Dorji, sent his brother, Ckökyi Gyeltsen, with two servants to meet Mahatma Gandhi in Borsad in Gujarat, India. He was instructed to tell the Mahatma that Bhutan used to be ruled by the shabdrungs, but not anymore. Ckökyi Gyeltsen asked Gandhi for help. But, as Michael Aris points out, 'it is difficult to think of a person more unsuited to joining a plot of this kind than Gandhi'.[26] The shabdrung then began to make plans to go to Tibet and from there if necessary to China. According to Aris, '[t]he Panchen Lama Ckökyi Nyima was at that time expected by some to return from a long exile with the support of a strong contingent of Chinese troops, and the *Shabdrung* hoped now to obtain help in wresting power from the king'.[27]

The druk gyalpo found out about the plot and had the shabdrung detained at Talo monastery in Punakha, where he resided. Then, on 12 November 1931, the shabdrung died. Whether he was killed or committed suicide is unclear, but he was the last shabdrung to be recognized officially. Since then there have been several claimants to the title of shabdrung, but they have all resided in India without any influence in Bhutan.

The first druk gyalpo had, before his death in 1926, sought and received British assurance that his family, the Wangchuks, would retain their prominent position in Bhutan. Thus, a royal lineage was established and the second druk gyalpo, Jigme Wangchuk, reigned unopposed until his death in 1952. He oversaw the transition of Bhutan's relationship with the British colonial power to the new agreement with independent India and personally ratified the 8 August 1949 Treaty of Perpetual Peace and Friendship between the Government of India and the Government of Bhutan. Indians made the same pledges as the British before them—to oversee Bhutan's foreign policy but leave internal governance to the Bhutanese—but some historians now believe that if India had been involved in a conflict with China at that time, as it was a decade later, it might not have agreed so easily to Bhutan's request for continuation of self-determination in its internal affairs.[28]